won the three-Test series 1–0. Most of the batsmen were in good form and we were hopeful of achieving our first ever series win Down Under. Unfortunately, before the first Test at the MCG there was only one warm-up game, as is often the case with scheduling these days, and even that was a near washout because of a storm, which meant we had very little chance to adjust to Australian conditions.

## First Test, Melbourne, 26–29 December 2007

We had a reasonable first day at the MCG, picking up nine Australian wickets, and we quickly finished off their innings the next morning for 343. Anil and Zaheer had bowled well and now it was down to the batsmen. I came in with the score at 31–2.

I had thought carefully about the way I would approach my innings and had a plan for each Australian bowler. In fact, a glance at my scoring chart for the series will show up where I played the big shots: I really went after the bowling in the area between long on and midwicket. This was based on my experience of playing the Australian attack in the one-dayers in India a couple of months before, when the left-arm chinaman bowler Brad Hogg had caused us problems. I was determined to attack him because I knew it would force the Australians to rethink their plans. If they couldn't rely on Hogg, the fast bowlers would have to bowl longer spells than expected and we could attack them when they got tired in the hot and testing conditions. I went into the Melbourne Test with a set plan against Hogg. However, once in the middle, I realized that I needed to play differently and changed my plan on the ground itself. Looking at his field placements, I started taking the aerial route and hit him in the area between deep midwicket and long on, forcing him to change his game plan and remove the close-catching fielders. This strategy paid off and I could subsequently milk singles, with no men close on the leg side. For other bowlers, however, I stuck to the same game plan that I had originally decided.

Brett Lee bowled at his best in this series. Back in 1999 Lee had been fast but raw; in 2008 he was the complete package. He had real pace, a vicious bouncer, a yorker, a fast swinging delivery and also a slower ball. He was consistently clocking 145 kph and I relished my contests with him. Among the other bowlers, Mitchell Johnson bowled some incisive